

Council Meeting
April 21, 2025, 5:00 pm

The Claremont City Council held an EMERGENCY meeting on Monday, April 21, 2025, in Council Chambers of City Hall. Mayor Girard called the meeting to order at 5:00 pm.

Members of the Council present included Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Motion to enter non-public Session under RSA 91-A, II (a) personnel made by Assistant Mayor Matteau, seconded by Councilor Limoges. Motion carried unanimously via roll call vote with the following voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Entered nonpublic at 5:03 pm.

The public meeting resumed at 5:46 pm. Motion to seal the minutes of this non-public session made by Councilor O'Hearne, seconded by Councilor Zutter, because it would adversely affect the reputation of a person other than a member of this board. Motion carried unanimously by roll call vote with the following voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Finance Director Bates and Chief Wilmot arrived at Council Chambers at 5:55 PM.

The following resolution was read by Assistant Mayor Matteau, seconded by Councilor Koloski.

Resolved:

Article III, Section 30 of the Claremont City Charter provides:

The city manager shall be the chief executive and administrative officer of the city government, and carry out the policies laid down by the city council. *He/she shall be responsible to the city council for the proper administration of all affairs of the city, but including the preservation of the public health, the safety of property and management of all municipally owned utilities and be in responsible charge of the maintenance, care, construction or otherwise of all streets, highways, bridges, sewers, parks, playgrounds, buildings and all other municipally owned structures. He/she shall keep the council informed of the condition and needs of the city and shall make such reports as may be required by law, this charter or ordinance, or may be requested by the council, and such other reports and recommendations as he/she may deem advisable, and perform such other duties as may be prescribed by this charter, or required of him/her by ordinance or resolution of the council not inconsistent with this charter.* He/she shall have and perform such other powers and duties not inconsistent with the provisions of this charter as now are or hereafter may be conferred or imposed upon him/her by municipal ordinance or upon mayors of cities by general law. He/she shall have the right to take part in the discussion of all matters coming before the council but not the right to vote.

In order to effectively and efficiently perform its duties as described in Article II, Section 23 of the Charter, the City Council is reliant on the City Manager to provide reliable, accurate, and timely information regarding the affairs of the City. Despite having deficiencies in this regard brought to his attention, both formally, and informally, the City Manager has failed or refused to produce information as requested. As has been brought to his attention, the City Council's concerns include:

1. Honesty:

The Council has noted and brought to the City Manager's attention a pattern of inconsistent communication with Councilors, including discrepancies in answers given to different Council members regarding the same questions. This inconsistency undermines transparency and trust. Additionally, a memo presented to the Council regarding carrying costs, the manager requested changes which raised serious concerns about the accuracy and timeliness of the information provided.

2. Continued concerns with lack of information in Council packets:

The Council has consistently requested that to support our ability to make informed decisions, Council packets (status reports and other requested information provided to the Council prior to Council meetings) be more detailed and informative. Despite the City Manager's assurance that he would review Council packets prior to their release to confirm that all requested and necessary information is provided, significant gaps in critical information remain. This includes essential details necessary for thorough evaluation of agenda items are still being omitted. The withholding or failure to provide information hinders the City Council in its ability to perform its duties.

3. Lack of follow-up communication with the entire Council:

From time to time, individual Councilors have made inquiries to the City Manager regarding issues. To promote clarity and efficiency, the City Manager was directed to share his responses to such inquiries with the entire City Council. However, he has failed or refused to consistently follow this directive, resulting in a lack of shared understanding of City affairs that interferes with the Council's ability to effectively perform its duties.

4. Lack of departmental control and accountability:

The City Manager has been directed to provide greater communication and oversight to municipal departments and to assess and improve departmental management and performance. The Council has seen little to no measurable improvement. The Council has observed that City departments under the direction of the City Manager proceed with projects without appropriate planning or adherence to established processes.

For these reasons, the City Council, pursuant to its authority under Article III, Section 28 of the City Charter, hereby votes to remove the City Manager from office and terminate his employment. It is further resolved a vote in favor of this resolution shall constitute a vote to immediately place the City Manager on a paid leave of absence, effective immediately, pending the outcome of any Article III, Section 28 procedures as may arise.

On behalf of the Claremont City Council,

Dale R. Girard
Mayor

Resolution was adopted by unanimous roll call vote with the following councilors voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne, seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau, to appoint Finance Director Nancy Bates and Police Chief Brent Wilmot, as Acting (Interim) Co-City Managers. Motion carried unanimously by roll call vote with the following voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Motion to enter non-public Session under RSA 91-A, II (a) personnel made by Counselor O'Hearne, seconded by Councilor Limoges, which included inviting Chief Wilmot and Director Bates. Motion carried unanimously via roll call vote with the following voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Entered non-public session at 6:00 pm.

The public meeting resumed at 6:18 pm. Motion to seal the minutes of this non-public session made by Councilor Koloski, seconded by Councilor Limoges, because it would adversely affect the reputation of a person other than a member of this board. Motion carried unanimously by roll call vote with the following voting in favor: Councilors Koloski, Greenrose, Limoges, Zutter, Hemingway, Hayden, O'Hearne, Assistant Mayor Matteau and Mayor Girard.

Motion to adjourn by Councilor Zutter, seconded by Councilor Hemingway. Motion carried unanimously by voice vote. Meeting adjourned at 6:19 pm.

Respectfully submitted,

Debora Matteau

Assistant Mayor